Generative AI Can Harm Teaching

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University of Pennsylvania

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Overview

1. In 14 Turkish schools, we **randomly assigned** 193 teachers to get a GPT-4o teaching assistant or teach as usual for one semester.
2. 78% used it, mostly to produce teaching material, with little back-and-forth.
3. Students' intrinsic motivation fell (–0.11 SD), most under teachers who already used AI heavily.
4. Confidence fell less, mainly under weaker teachers.
5. Standardized test scores did not move on average, but students of weaker teachers lost 0.13 SD.
6. Teachers' beliefs about AI did not change: a principal–agent problem.

Teachers already use generative AI

60%

of U.S. K-12 teachers used an AI tool last school year

Gallup & Walton Family Foundation 2025

1/3

use it every week

Gallup & Walton Family Foundation 2025

No causal evidence on its effects on students.

AI could increase or decrease the quality of teaching

Optimistic

High-quality content.

Time freed for rehearsal, relationships and differentiation.

Pessimistic

Teachers offload the pedagogical thinking.

Materials come out polished but generic.

Time saved might not be reinvested.

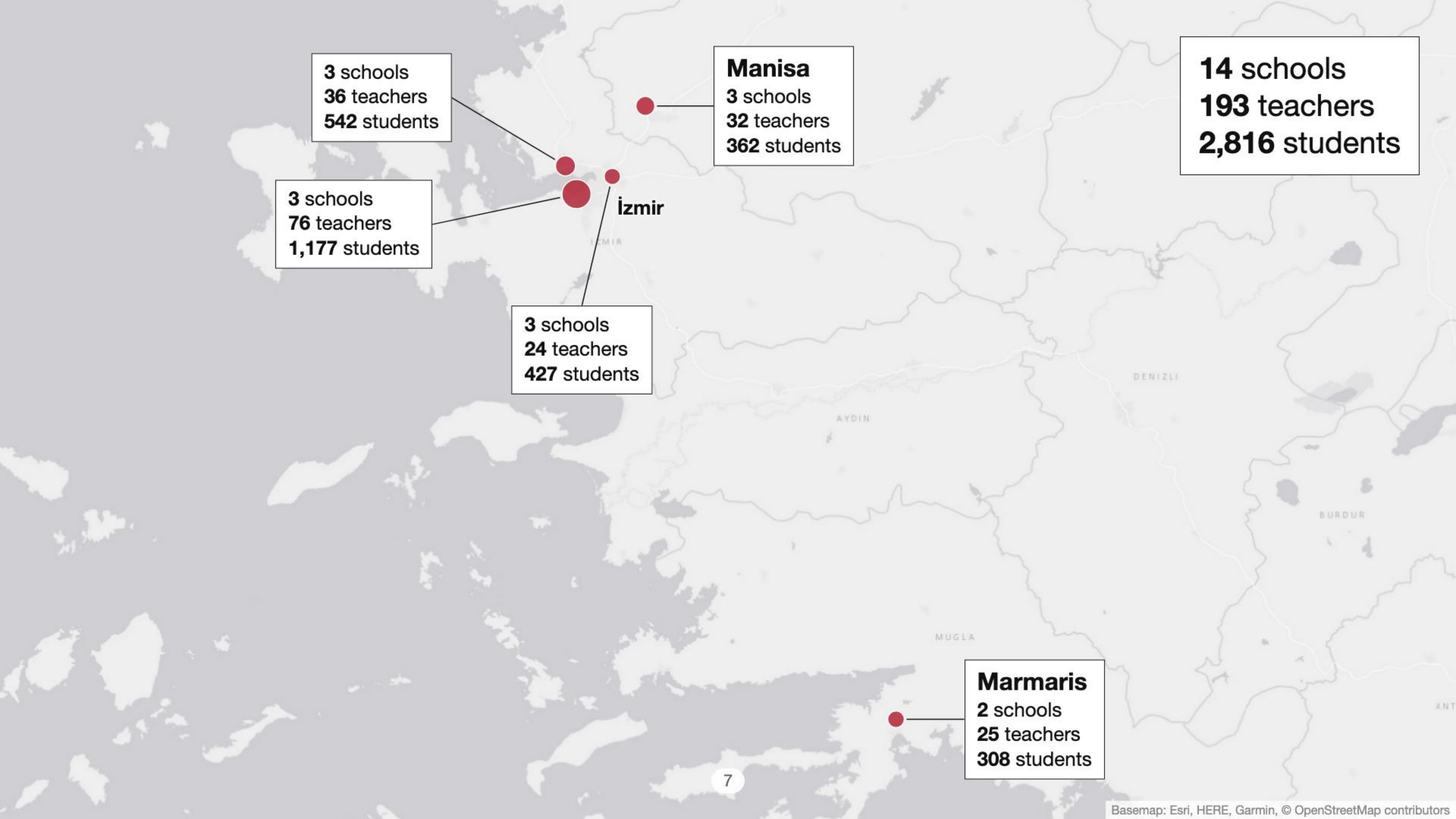
Oreopoulos et al. 2024
Doshi & Hauser 2024
Farber et al. 2014

Five questions about what happens when teachers use AI

1. Adoption: do teachers use the tool?
2. Usage: what do they use it for?
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A preregistered field experiment in 14 Turkish schools

14	schools, grades 5–12
85	school–department clusters
193	teachers
2,816	students
14,198	student–course observations


3 schools
36 teachers
542 students
Manisa
3 schools
32 teachers
362 students
14 schools
193 teachers
2,816 students
3 schools
76 teachers
1,177 students
İzmir
3 schools
24 teachers
427 students
Marmaris
2 schools
25 teachers
308 students
İZMIR
AYDIN
DENIZLI
MUGLA
BURDUR
Basemap: Esri, HERE, Garmin, © OpenStreetMap contributors

Control

Business-as-usual professional development

AI Access

A one-hour training and a custom GPT-4o tool built on the national curriculum

AI Access + Reminder

+ weekly emails showing each teacher's own usage, as a nudge

Both AI arms are **pooled** and compared with control.
Estimates are **intent-to-treat**.

Unit of randomization: the school–department

Details

ChatGPT-4 | Ders Plani Tasarlayici | Geri Bildirim Araci | Hata ve Kavram Yanılgısı Düzeltme | İdari İletisim Asistani | Ödev-Sınav Uretici

Öğrenci Destek ve Strateji Geliştirme Rehberi | Öğrenciler için stres yönetimi | Öğretmen İyi Oluş ve Destek Rehberi | Performans Analiz ve Geri Bildirim Asistani

Seviye ve İlgiye Göre Farklılaştırma | Unite Plani Tasarimi

Bu araç, Türkiye'deki öğretmenlere günlük ders planı hazırlarken rehberlik eder. Öğrencilerin ihtiyaçlarına uygun, anlamlı ve katılımcı ders etkinlikleri tasarlamayı kolaylaştırır. Pratik, anlaşılır ve yaratıcı öneriler sunarak öğretmenin hedeflerine ulaşmasını destekler. Ayrıca günlük ders planı tasarımına yönelik basit ve esnek öneriler sunar. Örnek Promptlar Kavram Odaklı Etkinlik Tasarımı "7. sınıf Fen Bilimleri dersinde 'Maddenin Halleri' konusunu daha somut ve eğlenceli hale getirmek için hangi etkinlikleri kullanabilirim?" Beceri Geliştirme Çalışmaları "5. sınıf Türkçe dersinde yazma becerilerini geliştirmek için hangi yaratıcı yazma etkinliklerini önerirsiniz?" Tartışma ve Katılımı Teşvik Edici Stratejiler "11. sınıf Sosyal Bilgiler dersinde 'Demokrasi ve İnsan Hakları' konusunu ele alırken öğrencilerin tartışmaya aktif katılımını sağlamak için hangi stratejiler etkili olabilir?"

Ders: Ders Seçiniz veya yazınız **Sınıf:** Sınıf Seçiniz veya yazınız **Tema/Ünite:** Tema/Ünite Seçiniz veya yazı

Haftalık Ders Saati: Saat giriniz **Üniteye Ayrılan Ders Saati:** Saat giriniz

Baslat

Ask anything. Type @ / # !

Your AI Usage Report This Week

AI Teaching Assistant team Sun, Feb 9, 2025

Hello Teacher,

Here is some data on your use of the AI tool:

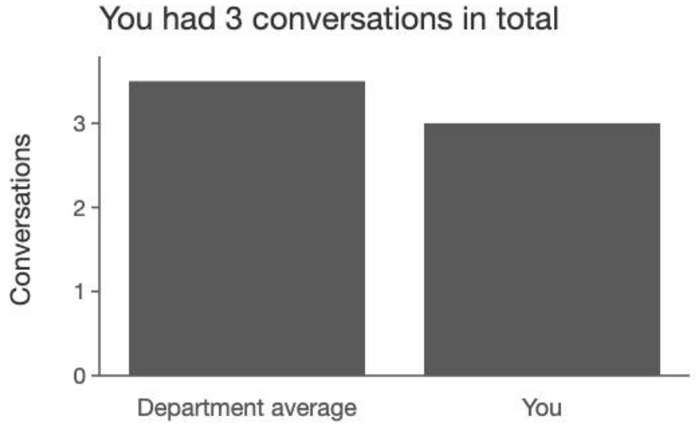
- You sent **8** messages.
- You had **3** conversations.
- You used the AI for about **1** minute in total.

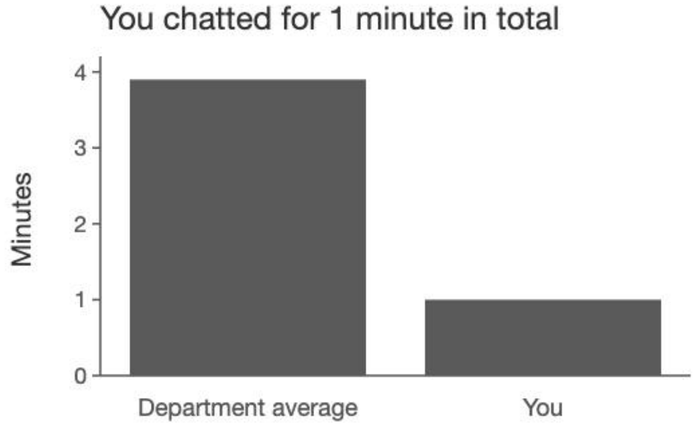
You've made a great start toward exploring more! Wishing you a successful new week.

Feel free to reach out with any questions.

Best wishes







Timeline

August–December 2024

Pre-period

Baseline standardized test scores collected

January 2025

Training

Teachers receive AI training and complete questionnaires

February–May 2025

Intervention Period

Treated teachers use AI tool
Control teachers teach as usual

Standardized test scores collected

May 2025

Endline

Teachers and students complete questionnaires

Fall Semester 2024

Winter Break

Spring Semester 2025

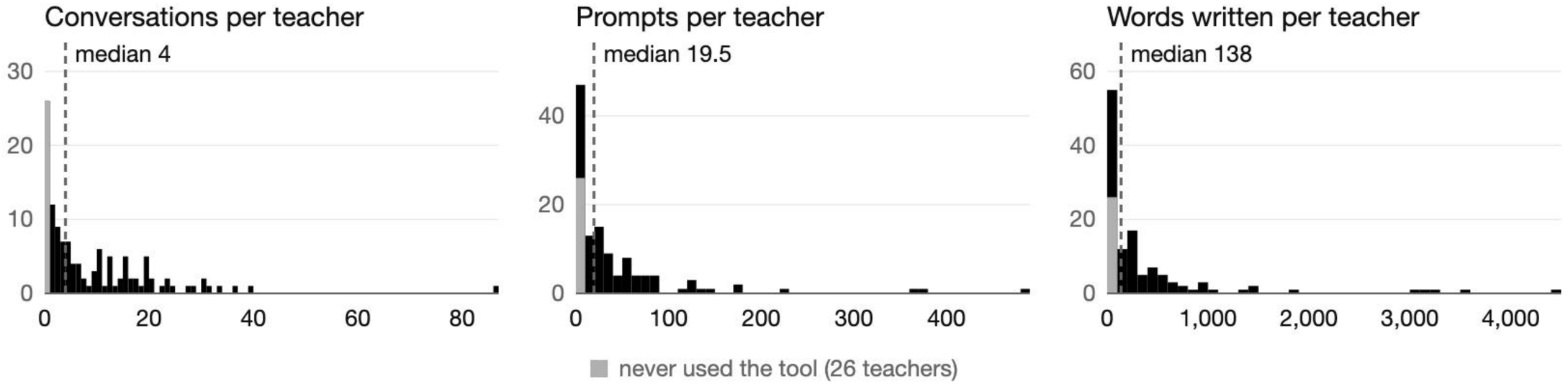
Five questions about what happens when teachers use AI

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Most teachers did adopt the AI tool

78%

of treated teachers (94 of 120) had at least one conversation

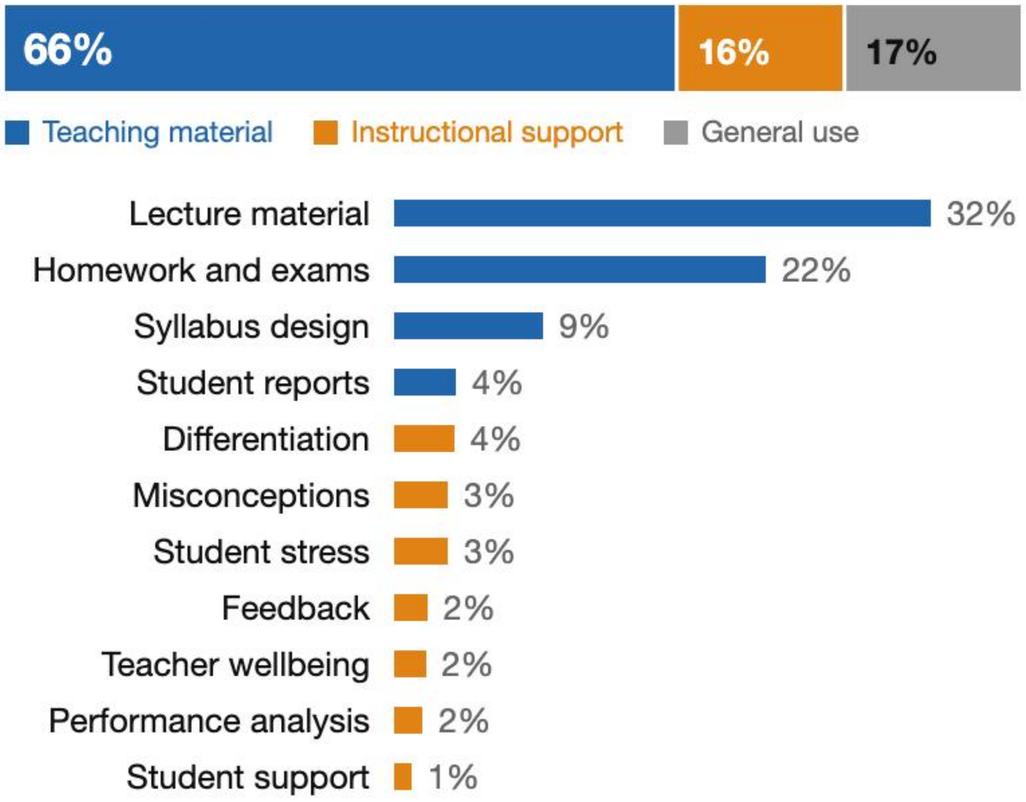


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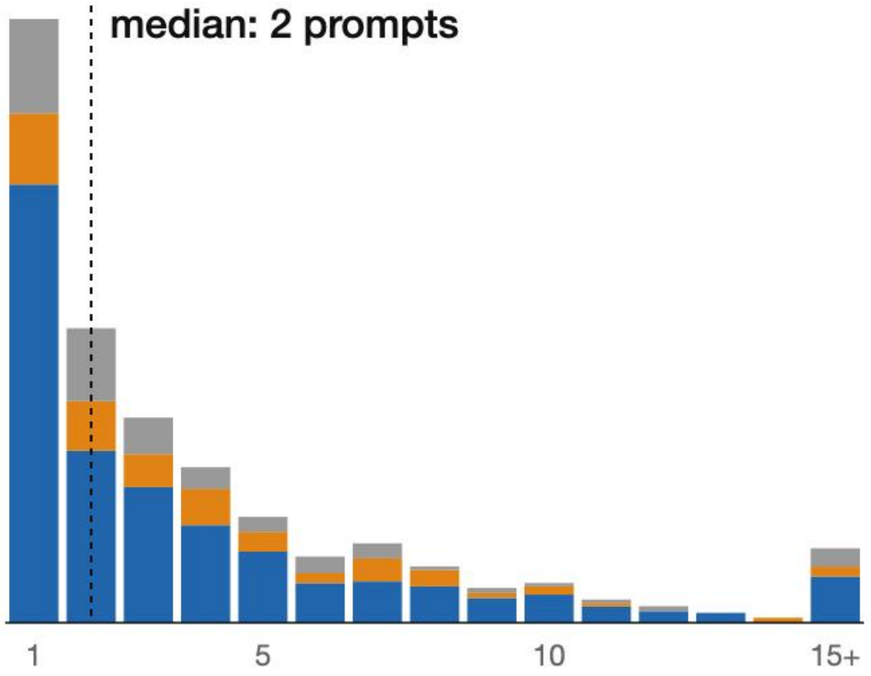
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Teachers used the AI tool in different ways

1,070 conversations from 94 teachers



Teacher prompts per conversation



Teachers delegated: they asked for finished materials and rarely iterated

66%

of conversations asked for teaching material: lectures, homework, exams, syllabi

16%

asked for instructional support: differentiation, misconceptions, feedback

2

teacher prompts in the median conversation

A chemistry teacher accepted the first lesson plan the tool offered

Teaching material

Lesson planning: a chemistry teacher, high school. From the tool logs, translated

Make an inference about how scientific knowledge changes through atomic theories.
Course: [Chemistry] Grade: [9th Grade]

Here is a concise plan:
1. Objective: explain how atomic theories changed.
2. Activity: timeline discussion.
3. Assessment: short-answer quiz.
[…]

Thank you, that's suitable.

You're welcome.

A department head asked the tool how to check on teachers' wellbeing

Instructional support

Wellbeing planning: a mathematics department head, high school. From the tool logs, translated

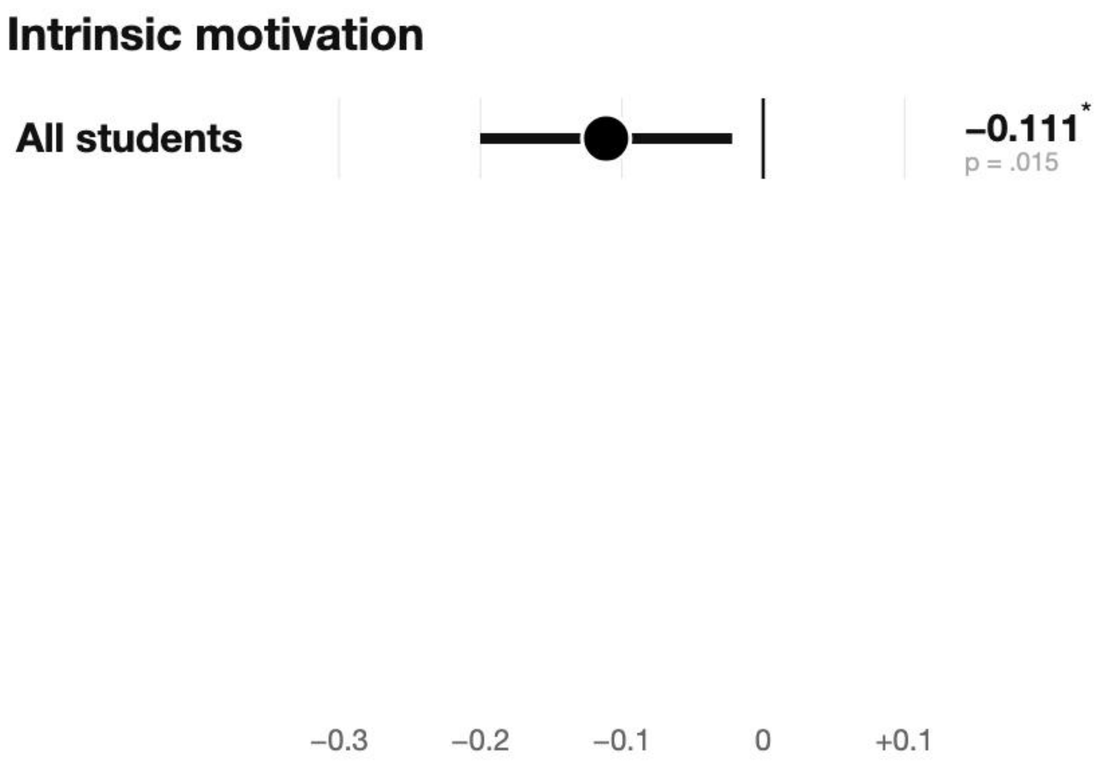
As a department head, how can I identify our teachers' state of wellbeing?

Of course. In high-school mathematics, stress may come from economic difficulties, achievement pressure, and limited resources.
Use anonymous pulse surveys, brief check-ins, and workload review. Then discuss supports such as shared planning time, peer mentoring, clearer priorities, and realistic self-care strategies. […]

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AI lowered students' intrinsic motivation

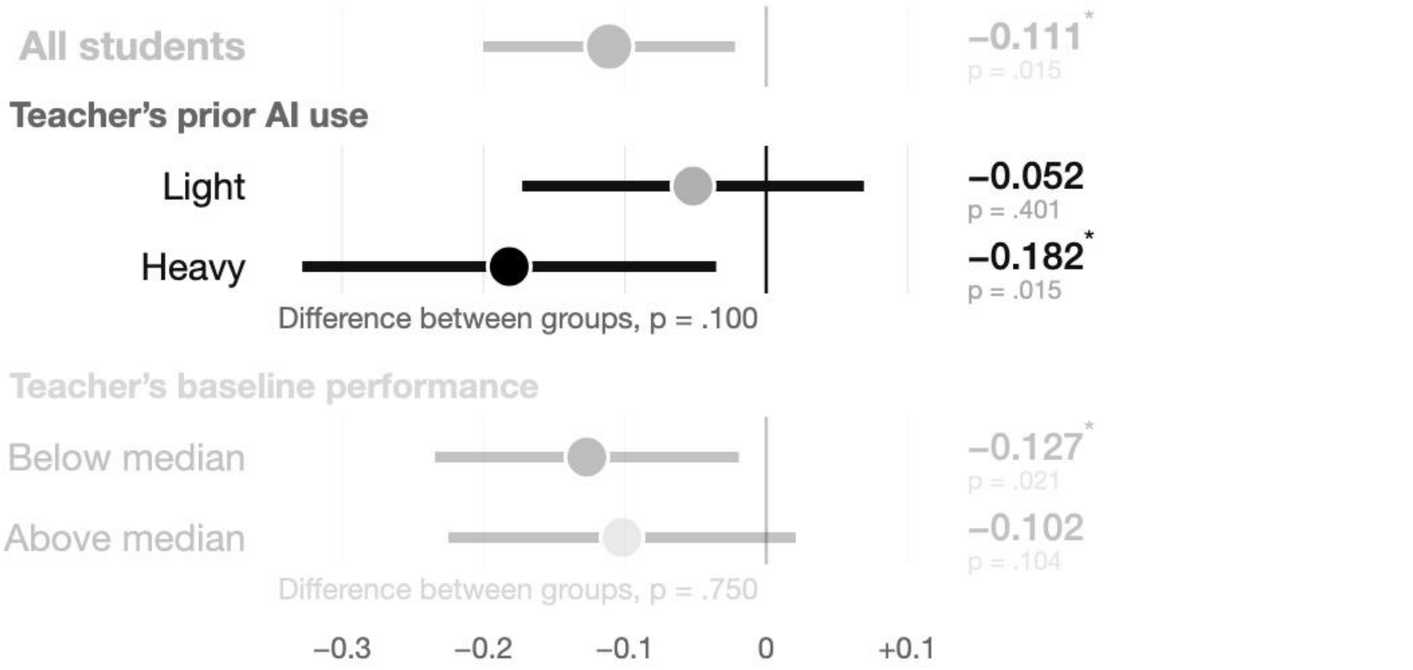


Details

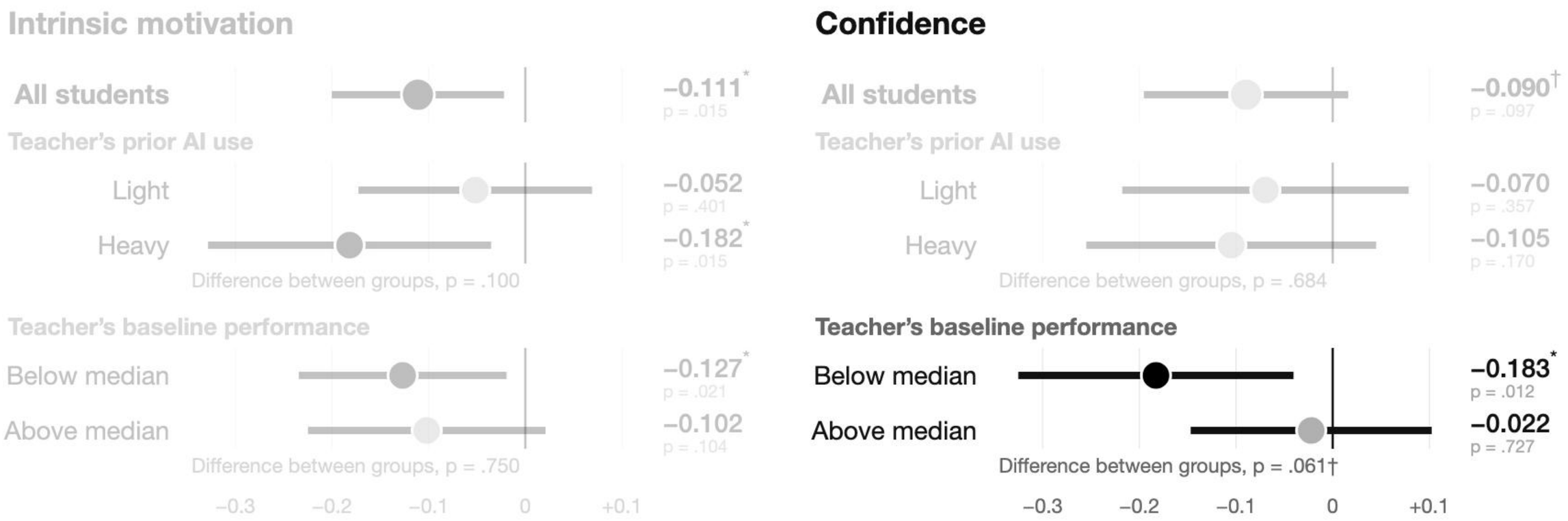
Fredricks et al. 2004

…especially for teachers higher in baseline AI use

Intrinsic motivation



Confidence fell less



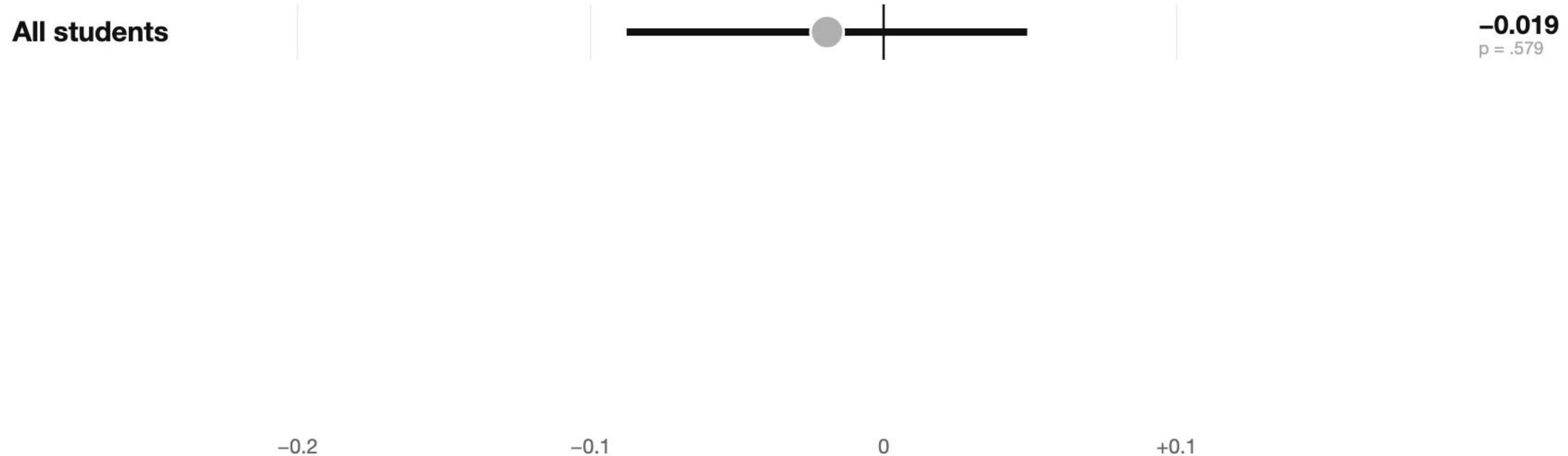
Standard deviations. Bars are 95% CIs

Five questions about what happens when teachers use AI

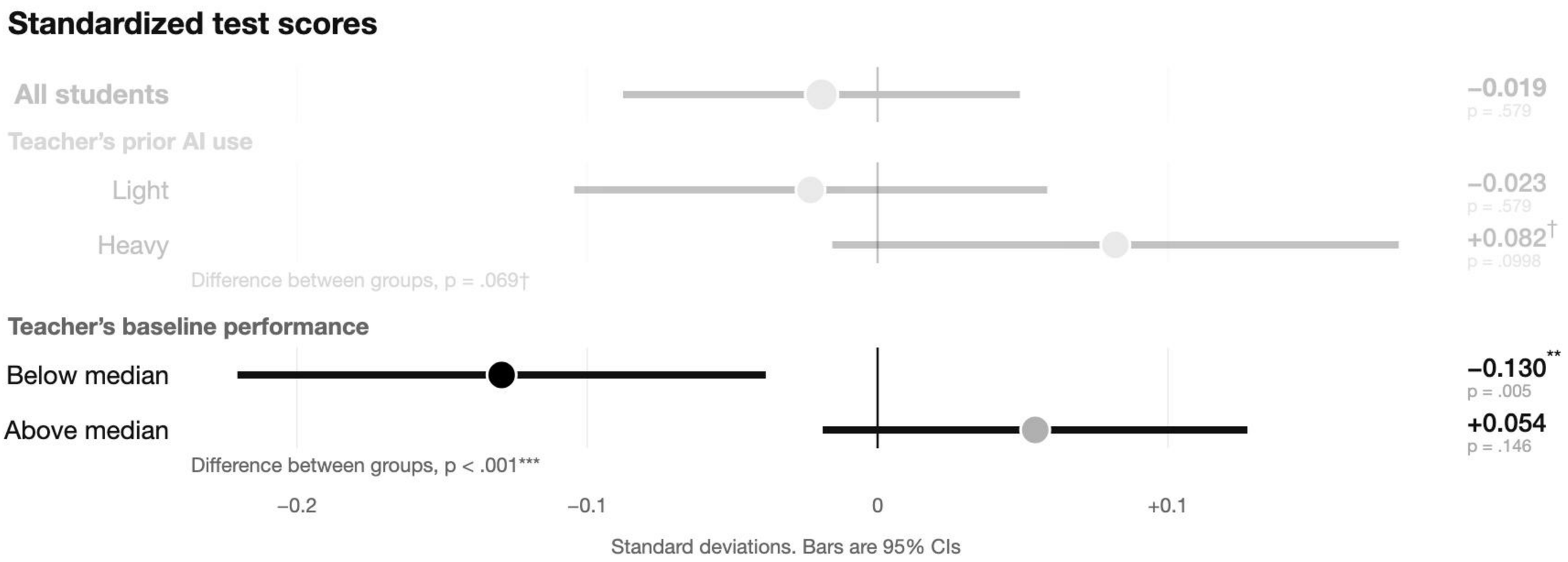
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On average, AI did not move standardized test scores

Standardized test scores



…but it did harm students of lower-performing teachers



Why was AI harmful?

Lost voice

AI-generated materials may be perceived as inauthentic.

Skill substitution

Weaker teachers are less able or willing to review, rehearse, internalize and modify AI output.

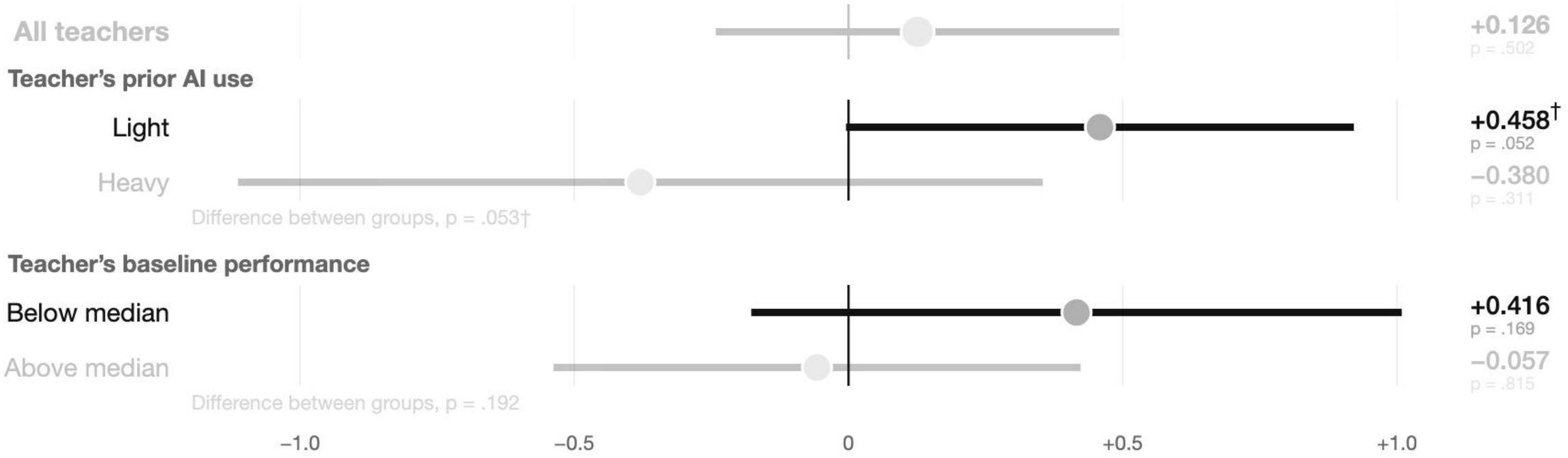
Doshi & Hauser 2024; Moon et al. 2026

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Teachers did not see the cost: a principal–agent problem

Teacher beliefs about AI



Standard deviations. Bars are 95% CIs

"What overall impact do you believe AI tools have on students' learning outcomes?"

Details

Limitations



Duration

We observe one semester.



Tool specificity

We test one AI tool design.



Contamination

Control teachers could use free AI tools, so our estimates are conservative.

We cannot assume AI helps in schools without more careful design

Optimists

We are too cautious and leave gains on the table.

Pessimists

Rapid adoption outruns our understanding of the harms.

Schools should scale AI for teachers with care.

Summary

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Thank you

Benjamin Lira, blira@upenn.edu

Paper

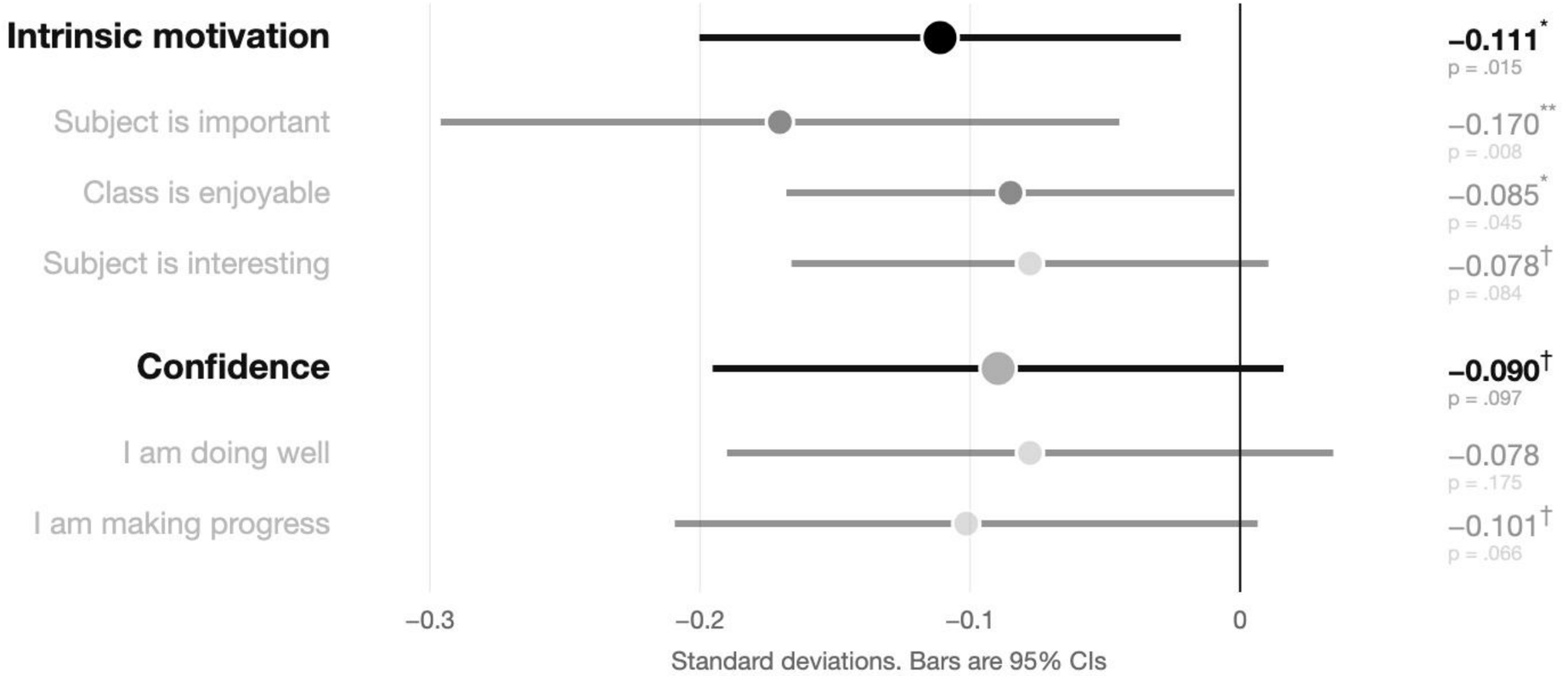
Code and data

The pattern survives the obvious checks

Attrition	Response rates did not differ by condition. Lee bounds stay negative.
Within-school variation	Every school had AI and control teachers.
Fixed effects	Still negative, though smaller, with department, school and student fixed effects.
Single items	No one survey item drives the result.
Arms and dosage	Same pattern for each AI arm and for AI-teacher share.

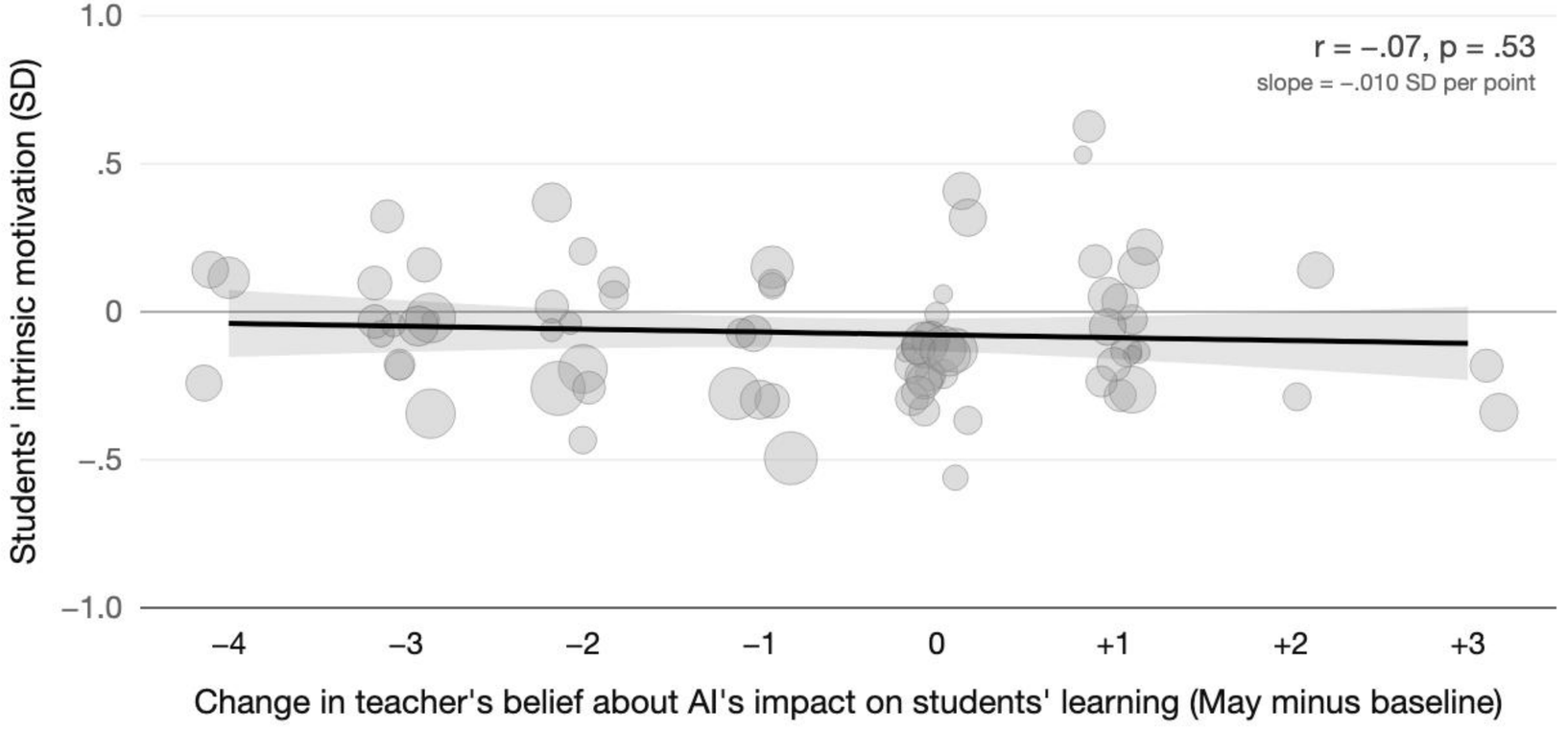
Lee (2009)

No single survey item drives the result



Back

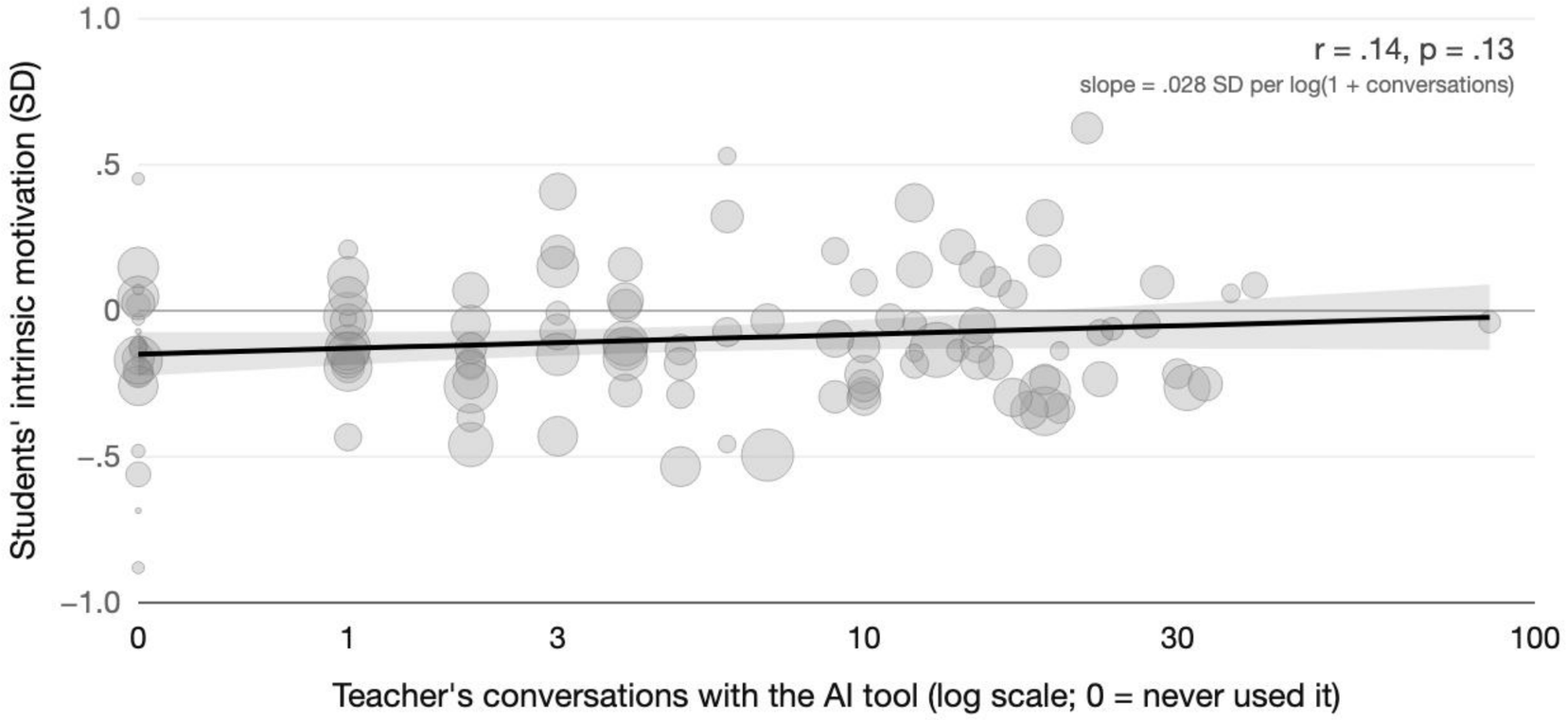
Teachers with less intrinsically motivated students did not grow more skeptical of AI



Descriptive; usage and beliefs were not randomized. N = 77 treated teachers. Dot area = number of surveyed students.

Back

Students' intrinsic motivation did not fall with heavier AI use



Descriptive; usage and beliefs were not randomized. N = 114 treated teachers. Dot area = number of surveyed students.

Estimation

$$Y_{ic} = \alpha + \boldsymbol{\beta} \cdot \mathrm{AI}_d + \gamma \cdot Y_{ic}^{\mathrm{pre}} + \varepsilon_{ic}$$

i student (or teacher), *c* course, *d* school–department (unit of randomization)

β: effect of giving teachers AI (intent-to-treat, both AI arms pooled)

γ: baseline control for test scores and teacher beliefs (students had no pre-survey)

Standard errors clustered by school–department

$$Y_{ic} = \alpha + \beta_1 \cdot \mathrm{AI}_d + \beta_2 \cdot M + \boldsymbol{\beta_3} \cdot (\mathrm{AI}_d \times M) + \gamma \cdot Y_{ic}^{\mathrm{pre}} + \varepsilon_{ic}$$

β_3: does the effect differ by the teacher's prior AI use or baseline performance?
M = 1 if the teacher is above the median

Back